POU33201 — Mid-term essay

30% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

Dr Noah Buckley

Weight	30% of the module mark
Length	2,000 words, 10% either way, excluding bibliography
Due	Sunday 1 November 2026, 23:59
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Assignment Submission Form as page 1

The task

Pick a real country at a real moment, any time from 1900 to the 2030s. Work out how an authoritarian regime could be built there, and how it would last for at least fifteen years.

The country can be a democracy at that moment, in which case you are describing how democracy is lost. Or it can already be an autocracy, in which case you are replacing one authoritarian regime with a different kind.

Use the module's tools (the elite and mass problems, power-sharing, repression, co-optation, parties, elections) on a case concrete enough that you have to be specific and analytical. Write as an analyst, from inside the regime's own logic. This is not fiction writing, though you can and should be creative!

What to cover

1. **The starting point.** Where and when, what regime is in place, and why this country is vulnerable at this moment.
2. **Taking power.** Who leads (a real person or party wherever possible), how they take power (a coup, a self-coup, a civil war, a party that wins and then stays, gradual backsliding, something else), what justification they give, and what kind of regime you are building.
3. **The first five years.** The two problems every dictator faces:
   - **The elite.** Who is in the ruling coalition, what does each faction want, and what stops them turning on the leader?
   - **Everyone else.** How does the regime keep the rest of the population in line: repression, co-optation, elections, or a mix?
4. **The long run.** What keeps the regime going for fifteen years or more? Where does the money come from? What happens when the leader dies or goes?

These are prompts, not a checklist: spend your words where your case is most interesting.

Requirements

- **An argument**, stated in the introduction: in a sentence or two, why your regime holds.
- **The module's concepts**, used as tools and cited to the readings.
- **Outside reading on your country**: its history, parties, factions, constitution, economy. Include academic literature beyond the required readings.
- A **bibliography**, in any consistent style.

Marked on argument, analysis, use of evidence, structure and writing.

Optional: one diagram. A map of the factions in the ruling coalition, a chart of the regime's institutions, or a timeline. Use it to show how the regime works, not to decorate!

Rules

- **Something *new* must be built.** "What if the USSR had never fallen" doesn't count: a regime that simply carries on is not the task here.
- **There are no extra marks for building a regime you think I'd approve of** or for having it collapse or democratize early. Keep the tone neutral and analytical.

Choosing a case

Three suggestions:

- **The obvious answer could be the weakest.** A far-right party wins an election in Western Europe, captures the media and the courts, and that is the essay. Basically just Hungary once more. This risks avoiding the really core, interesting stuff: how exactly was the election won, and what do the factions inside the ruling party want from each other, and so on?
- **Closed regimes and civil wars work well.** A party-state or a military junta forces you to spell out the whole apparatus. So does a civil war won by the side that actually lost, because then the winner can't simply become a democracy.
- **Pick a country you're willing to read about.** You need its politics in detail.

Some examples to start from. You are **definitely** not limited to these.

- The anti-Treaty side wins the Irish Civil War, 1922–23.
- The Whites win the Russian Civil War.
- The Republicans win the Spanish Civil War, 1939.
- Fascists take power in Britain in the 1930s. (There were popular fascists in Britain!)
- The Kuomintang wins the Chinese Civil War, 1949.
- Mossadegh survives the 1953 coup in Iran and rules by decree.
- Hugo Chávez's 1992 coup in Venezuela succeeds.

Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	This is the expected answer.
Brainstorming	**Not permitted.** Choosing your case and designing the regime is the assignment.
Research/learning assistance	**Permitted for one thing only:** clarifying a term or passage you could not follow after genuinely trying. Not for researching your case or summarising readings.
Writing assistance	**Not permitted.** Spellcheck is fine.
Direct AI content inclusion	**Not permitted.**
Other use	Describe it on the form. If in doubt, ask me *before* the deadline; asking is never held against you.

The Assignment Submission Form must be page 1 of every written submission. A submission without a completed form is not accepted.

Word limits, late work and extensions

See the module outline.

Adapted from Julian Waller's "Build a Regime" assignment at George Washington University.